FREE GUIDE

The Human-First Operations Checklist

Work that connects.

A practical way to check the health of your operations,
from systems and workflows to team cadence and culture.

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HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

Start with what is true today.

This checklist is for founders, CEOs, nonprofit leaders, school district leaders, and workspace owners who want a clear picture of how their organization is running today. It covers six areas, with six statements in each. Read each one and check it only if it is true right now.

Be honest with yourself, and leave judgment out of it. An unchecked box is useful information, not a failing grade. I believe people do their best work when they have access to knowledge and resources they may not otherwise have, and this guide is one small way to share how I look at operations. Use it on your own, with your team, or bring it to our first conversation.

1

Strategy and Direction

Clear direction gives every other part of the work something to point toward.

- [ ] Our leadership team can state our top three priorities for this year in plain language.
- [ ] Everyone on the team knows how their role supports those priorities.
- [ ] We have a way to decide what to say no to, and we use it.
- [ ] Our goals are written down, with owners and dates.
- [ ] We review progress on a regular schedule, not only when something goes wrong.
- [ ] When circumstances change, we adjust the plan and tell people why.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

2 Systems and Workflows

Good systems carry the routine work so people have room for the work that needs judgment.

- [ ] Our core processes are documented in a place everyone can find.
- [ ] Each recurring task has a clear owner and a clear handoff.
- [ ] A new team member can learn how things work without relying on one person's memory.
- [ ] We know where work tends to get stuck, and we have a plan to address it.
- [ ] We review and update our processes at least once a year.
- [ ] If a key person were out for two weeks, the work would keep moving.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

3 People and Culture

Performance and wellbeing rise together when people feel trusted, clear, and heard.

- [ ] Each person knows what is expected of them and how their work is measured.
- [ ] People receive feedback regularly, not only at review time.
- [ ] Team members feel safe raising problems and disagreeing respectfully.
- [ ] Our values show up in how we hire, recognize good work, and make hard decisions.
- [ ] Workloads are visible and realistic, and leaders notice early signs of burnout.
- [ ] People have a clear path to learn, grow, and take on more responsibility.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

4 Communication and Team Cadence

Most operational problems are communication problems in disguise, so this section deserves a careful look.

- [ ] We keep a regular meeting rhythm, and each meeting has a clear purpose.
- [ ] Leaders and team members have recurring one on one conversations.
- [ ] Important decisions are recorded, including who made them and why.
- [ ] People know which channel to use for urgent, routine, and shared updates.
- [ ] Information that affects the whole team reaches everyone at about the same time.
- [ ] When there is tension or a misunderstanding, we address it directly and early.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

5 Tools, Data, and AI

The right tools support your people, and the wrong ones quietly add to their workload.

- [ ] Our tools match how we actually work, and we are not maintaining ones we do not use.
- [ ] Our key information lives in one trusted place, not scattered across inboxes and personal files.
- [ ] We track a small set of numbers that tell us whether the organization is healthy.
- [ ] Team members know how to use our core tools well, and training is available.
- [ ] We have clear guidelines for how AI tools may be used, including what information stays private.
- [ ] We try new tools with a clear purpose and a small pilot before rolling them out widely.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

6 Equity and Access

Fair access to information and opportunity makes an organization stronger and its work more trusted.

- [ ] Important information is shared openly, not held by a few people.
- [ ] Everyone has the training, tools, and support they need to do their job well.
- [ ] Hiring, promotion, and pay decisions follow criteria that are clear and consistently applied.
- [ ] Meetings and communications work for people with different roles, schedules, and working styles.
- [ ] Newer and quieter voices have real ways to contribute to decisions.
- [ ] We ask the people we serve what they need and what gets in their way.

Checked in this section: _____ / 6

YOUR SCORE

How to Read Your Results

Count the statements you checked, out of 36. If a statement is only partly true, leave it unchecked for now.

My total: _____ / 36

30 to 36	You have a strong foundation. Your work now is to protect what is working, keep it documented, and look for the one or two areas where a small refinement would make the biggest difference.
18 to 29	You have a solid base and clear opportunities. The unchecked items show you where to focus, and most teams find that improving one area makes the others easier.
Under 18	You have a lot of room to build, and that is a useful place to start because your priorities are easy to see. Pick one section and begin there. You do not need to fix everything at once.

NEXT STEPS

What to Do Next

1. Find the one section with the most unchecked items and choose a single statement from it to work on this month.
2. Book a free Discovery Conversation if you would like to talk through your results. We will start by listening to what is going on, and there is no pressure to commit to anything.
3. If you want to go deeper, a Strategy Session or an Operations Clarity Audit can give you focused, senior-level input on the areas that matter most.

You can reach me at **hello@jessicadmaine.com** or visit **jessicadmaine.com**.

Thank you for taking the time to look closely at your organization. Wherever you landed, you have taken a useful first step.

> *I believe in equity by giving people access to the knowledge and resources they may not otherwise have, so they can bridge the gap between vision and fruition.*

-Jessica